

DEVELOPMENT IMPACT NEWSLETTER

EDUCATION: A KEY TO PEACE, PROGRESS, AND DEVELOPMENT



The United Nations proclaimed January 24th as the **International Day of Education**, celebrating education as a **human right**, a **public good** and a **public responsibility** all at once.

DIME embraces the importance of mainstreaming education worldwide, recognizing its transformative power in fostering innovation and dismantling barriers to opportunity.

In a rapidly evolving world, education stands as the cornerstone of peace, progress and sustainable development.

This newsletter highlights four of our impact evaluations on education showcasing how **effective policy making can empower communities**:

1. In **Jordan** and **the Gambia**, we demonstrated the importance of school meals on learning outcomes.
2. In **Brazil**, we showed that increasing teacher autonomy can improve student performance.
3. In **Uganda**, we demonstrated the power of education scholarships on reducing poverty.
4. In **Nigeria**, we found community screenings and mobile phones can be a cost-effective solution to alleviating the learning poverty crisis.

THE POWER OF HEALTHY MEALS: DATA FROM JORDAN AND GAMBIA

In partnership with the World Food Programme (WFP), DIME is producing evidence on the role of school feeding programs and their combination with teacher incentives and as child safety nets against absenteeism and dropout.

In **Jordan**, the average number of **absence days** **reduces by 15%** when changing the meal composition:



Provision of school meals and teacher incentives significantly reduced dropouts in **the Gambia**:



Date bars

healthy meal

No intervention

Any intervention

Fig. 1a: Impact evaluation in Jordan
(2022-2023 school year)

Fig. 1b: Impact evaluation in the Gambia



Regular access to healthy school meals lead to a 1 day reduction in school absences per child in Jordan. Children themselves say they are more focused in class.

In Gambia, school feeding halved grade repetition and lowered reports of stress among students, especially girls.

Our research shows that school feeding and teacher incentives bring students to the classroom and improves their wellbeing.

* The World Bank, World Food Programme, 2021. "[School-based programme \(SBP\) Impact Evaluation Window](#)"

TEACHERS' AUTONOMY IMPROVES EDUCATIONAL OUTCOMES: EXPERIMENTAL EVIDENCE FROM BRAZIL

What is the impact of greater teacher autonomy on student learning?



In **Brazil**, our impact evaluation demonstrated that giving teachers more autonomy improves student learning and reduces teacher turnover.

We used a randomized controlled trial to evaluate the impact of a state school policy that empowered teachers to increase student motivation. This policy ("Pedagogical Innovative Project") was implemented in Rio Grande do Norte, one of the poorest states in Brazil.

The evaluation shows significant **increase in passing rates (8.5 pp. or 13%)** and **learning gains equivalent to half an extra year of schooling**. The effects concentrate in grade 6, a grade characterized by the highest repetition and dropout rates in the Brazilian lower-secondary education. The study finds suggestive evidence that teacher motivation and the quality of project implementation were two key factors underlying the impacts of the school program.

The results show that increasing public servant autonomy can enhance education service delivery in low-capacity contexts.

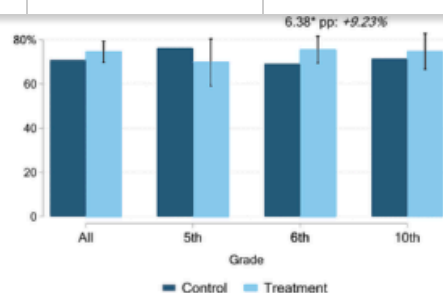


Fig. 2a: Impact on Teacher Retention

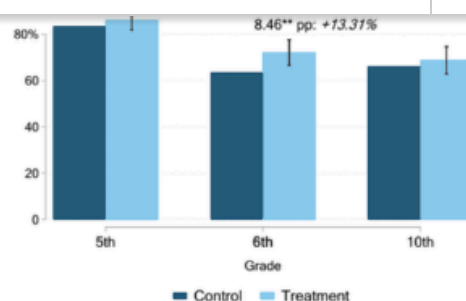


Fig. 2b: Impact on Passing Grade

* Caio Piza, Astrid Zwager, Matteo Ruzzante, Rafael Dantas, Andre Loureiro, 2024. "[Teacher-Led Innovations to Improve Education Outcomes: Experimental Evidence from Brazil](#)"

EDUCATION SCHOLARSHIPS AND POVERTY REDUCTION: EVIDENCE FROM UGANDA

The Mastercard Foundation Scholars Program in **Uganda** supports high-achieving students entering secondary school. The program provides **help with school fees, placement in top schools, education material, mentorship, and a stipend for economically disadvantaged students.**

DIME used random assignment methods to evaluate how the program affects both the students and their households. The results showed significant **positive impacts on student enrollment and test scores.** Simultaneously, **households experienced improvements in consumption, assets, well-being, and nutrition.**

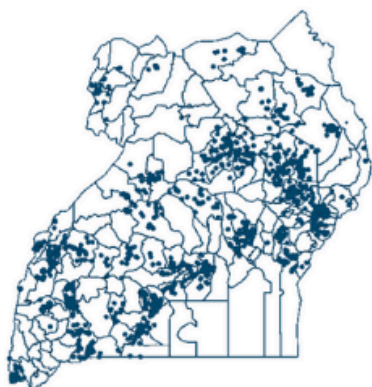


Fig. 3: Target household distribution in Uganda

By studying the roll-out of a scholarship program in secondary schools in Uganda, DIME uncovered the impact of education on poverty reduction and community empowerment.

The findings prove that scholarship programs can bring about positive change in education outcomes as well as multi-faceted poverty alleviation for associated households.

* Benedetta Lerva, Denise Ferris, Margherita Fornasari, 2023. "[A Multifaceted Education Program for the Poor and Talented](#)"

EDUCATION TECHNOLOGY AND HOME LEARNING: MOBILIZING MOBILE PHONES IN NORTHERN NIGERIA

DIME's recent study in **Nigeria** examined the



22% increase in parents reading to their children among treated households, and a notable 25% decrease in parents who perceived their own education as a hindrance to supporting their children's learning.

Additionally, the intervention had **substantial spillover effects on other household members**. For older, non-targeted siblings, the study found learning gains of 0.34 and 0.47 standard deviations in literacy and numeracy, along with **reductions in the likelihoods of teenage pregnancy** (by 13%) and **early entrance into the labor market** (by 14%).



Photo credit: World Bank/Laura Costica

These results underscore the potential of innovative approaches to expanding access to education in fragile settings.

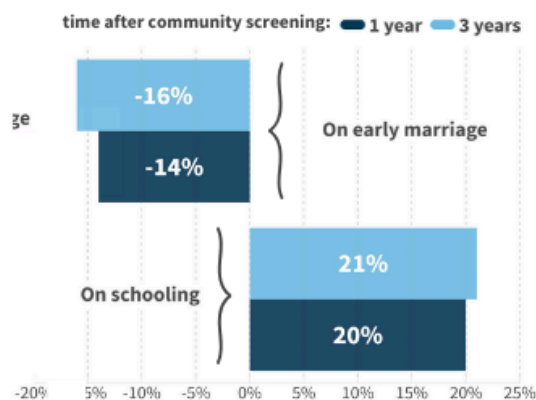


Fig. 4a: Change in parental aspirations on their daughters getting married early, and on their children stopping schooling at 18 (treatment: community screenings + provision of smartphones preloaded with literacy apps for 40% of attendees)

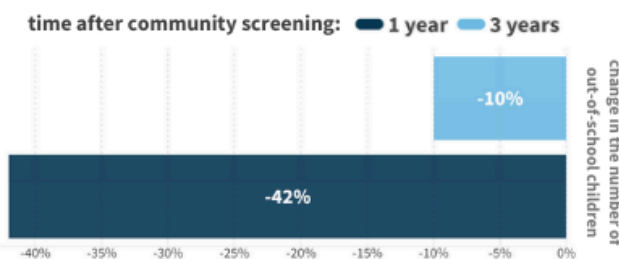


Fig. 4b: Impact on the number of out of school children (treatment: community screenings only)

The COVID-19 pandemic has exacerbated the learning poverty crisis in Sub-Saharan Africa, affecting nearly 9 children out of 10. However, gamified educational apps in local languages, running on cost-effective mobile phones, can make a significant difference in literacy and numeracy. These apps not only provide essential learning tools but also contribute to social and behavioral change through engaging narratives.

* Victor Orozco-Olvera, 2022. "Edutainment and Edtech for Effective Home Learning"

Learn More About DIME's
Edutainment Program

Learn More About DIME's
Gender Program



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